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AN ETHNOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS OF LATINO GAY YOUTH'S PATHS TO HOMELESSNESS

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This chapter examines chief processes, strategies, and tools for analyzing qualitative data for an ethnographic study of the relationship between sexual orientation and housing instability among Latino young gay and bisexual (LYGB) men in New York City (Castellanos, 2016). Concrete examples illustrate how the analytical process was embodied in material practices in which textual sources were manipulated and textual analysis generated in a systematic iterative process.

The disproportionate impact of homelessness among lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) youth (Ray, 2006), the scarce qualitative research, and the sensitivity of the subject demanded an exploratory and flexible methodology. A central aim was to examine the role of family conflict related to sexual orientation in creating housing instability among LYGB men. I relied primarily on ethnographic methods to study social interactions and settings (Agar, 1996), and on grounded theory approach for guiding the data analysis (Charmaz & Belgrave, 2012; Corbin & Strauss, 1996).

Fieldwork was conducted for 18 months at a community-based organization (CBO) serving LGBT homeless youth and in social venues frequented by LGBT youth. Data came from three main sources: (a) research articles, (b) fieldwork (50 pages of fieldnotes and jottings from informal interviews with youth and staff), (c) recorded single semi-structured interviews with 14 LYGB men (368 pages of transcripts), and (d) multiple semi-structured interviews with five service providers (130 pages of transcripts).

I identified three main pathways to homelessness (see Castellanos, 2016). First, some youth became homeless after systemization in foster care or group homes resulting from family abuse and neglect. In the second pathway, youth became homeless due to severe family conflict rooted in cultural and religious views on sexual orientation, masculinity, and gender performance. The third and most

common pathway occurred when sexual orientation was layered on top of pre-existing family conflict, creating *pressure cookers* that ended in the youth being kicked out or leaving home. Each pathway had concrete implications for future housing stability. Youth with fewer experiences of systemization and more stable family situations held richer social networks, stronger human capital, and more negative views on homelessness. They were also more likely to transition out of homelessness faster. Regardless of their pathway, most youth found a supportive and accepting environment in homeless networks that sometimes was hard to abandon.

The project embraced the dialogic nature of ethnography (Campbell & Lasiter, 2014; Tedlock, 1987) by maintaining concurrent comparisons between previous research findings (e.g., Lock & Steiner, 1999; Prendergast, Dunne, & Telford, 2002), the participants' understandings of their experiences, and my interpretations. Additionally, I used a flexible approach when selecting the analytical strategy or tool most appropriate to the analytical phase. In particular, I borrowed from inductive strategies of grounded theory (Charmaz & Belgrave, 2012) for developing analytical categories and domain and componential analysis (Spradley, 2016) to generate plausible causal pathways to homelessness.

Due to previous familiarity with ATLAS.ti, a computer-assisted qualitative data analysis (CAQDAS) software program, I chose it to support the different analysis stages in a systematized, visible, and documented manner (Fielding & Lee, 2002). A variety of CAQDAS programs exist, including NVivo, ATLAS.ti, QDA Miner, and MAXQDA. These programs are especially suited for implementing strategies associated with grounded theory projects through extensive and systematic data management capabilities and strong semantic and visual analytical tools.

Data analysis was not a linear process but an iterative one that contextualized, decontextualized, and recontextualized past research findings, transcripts, and fieldnotes. Each iteration involved research material practices (e.g., coding) that produced material objects—new textual materials that can be communicated, replicated, verified, and contested (Denzin & Lincoln, 2000; Konopásek, 2007). Albeit more complex, arduous, and time consuming, these iterations resulted in a more rigorous, comprehensive, and detailed analysis.

This chapter's first section discusses data analysis as a process of data reduction and generation through concurrent comparison. The following section examines some data analysis methods, strategies, and related tools used to develop a conceptual framework of homelessness pathways among LYGB men. I end the chapter with some reflections about the process of analyzing qualitative data in flexible and multifaceted methodologies such as ethnography.

The Concurrency of Data Collection and Analysis

Data collection and analysis consisted of overlapping, iterative, and increasingly focused steps. Analysis of the literature, fieldnotes, and transcripts of semi-structured

interviews guided later theoretical sampling, suggested additional questions, and outlined issues for triangulation and member checking. Conversely, the new data collected suggested additional, albeit more narrowly focused, analytical tasks and literature reviews. Within this approach, fieldnotes were both a data collection and an analytical tool (Bernard, 1998). Similarly, informal interviews and semi-structured interviews became increasingly responsive to the analytical needs of the project. Finally, rapid literature reviews were embedded within data analysis to explore themes and concepts.

Utilizing Fieldnotes as Primary Data and as an Analytical Tool

I conducted approximately 400 hours of fieldwork over a period of 18 months. Fieldnotes described my observations at public venues and participation in service delivery as well as notes from the informal interviews with youth and staff described earlier. The fieldwork products consisted of several small notebooks filled with handwritten notes. After typing and editing them in Microsoft Word, the resulting 24 single-spaced page document was added to ATLAS.ti for analysis.

Early in the project, fieldnotes were more descriptive in nature. Later, they became more analytical, resembling analytical memos and narrowing the boundaries between data collection and analysis. Table 13.1 shows two fragments of fieldnotes, one from the first month of fieldwork and another six months later.

Given that fieldnote taking is in itself a process of identifying, describing, and/or categorizing the phenomena observed, I skipped standard grounded theory coding when analyzing fieldnotes. Instead, I identified their importance to the research questions and coded overarching central themes. The result was a series of codes and analytical memos within ATLAS.ti. Table 13.2 shows a fragment of a memo after coding the fieldnotes.

Sometimes, early analysis of fieldnotes guided later data collection. For instance, fieldnotes and institutional reports revealed early on that a high percentage of clients served were African Americans as compared to Hispanics, the focus of this study. This information was used for tailoring later informal and semi-structured interviews with staff. The following are the fieldnotes from an informal interview with an HIV Counselor during fieldwork.

I ASKED S: How is that AA [African Americans] account for the largest percentage at the Center? According to S, who is half Mexican and half AA, most AA come from out of state (is the data kept somewhere?). He also reported that most Hispanics come from in-state (where?). He reported that young black men might be more transient. "Because they think it's easier to be homeless *and gay* in NYC, lots of AA come from the South, mostly from poor neighborhoods." Check migration patterns in the literature.

TABLE 13.1 Fragment of a Fieldnote

Fragment of an early fieldnote:

Space: [CBO] reaching out capacity; what happens when someone is waiting to come inside? Some people are requested to leave. No more than 20 clients at a time. Not allowed to hang out, clients must go to a group. How is that managed? It was decided that [staff's name] will take care of it by asking people to leave. However, last week it was said that it's better to get someone else to ask rather than a facilitator because it can change the dynamics of the group.

Fragment of later fieldnote:

Traffic control involves a variety of tasks geared to maintain an appropriate degree of flow of clients in the services areas. It includes allowing or restricting access to the site based on regulations and sanctions. [...] But traffic control seems fluid and subjective. A staff described to me how she had to develop a "feel for when the space is crowded." As she explained it, "how crowded the place is depends on how many people but also on who the people are."

TABLE 13.2 Fragment of a Memo and Related Memos

MEMO: family conflict: relation between sexual orientation and perceived gay lifestyle (Super, 2010-02-10 17:53:38)

[Related] Memos: ["being stuck" because of "gay lifestyle"] [conflict with parents over gay lifestyle] [Distinction between conflict over sexual orientation and sexual behavior] [...]

Type: Theory

[...]

Parents and their children might understand home conflict differently, often conflating issues of sexual orientation with gay-related lifestyle or previous behavioral issues. The actual event leading to the youth to leave home or the parent to kick him/her out might be confusing to both parties. [Staff] makes also a distinction between knowing that the child is gay versus assuming. In some cases, parents seem to know (according to the kids) but there is no overt conflict about their sexuality.

The concurrent and iterative analysis of fieldnotes and gathering of new data further allowed me to then conduct more focused semi-structured interviews. For instance, key themes from fieldnotes on the relation between gender performance and family conflict were later explored in subsequent interviews with the same or different people through informal or semi-structured interviews, providing me with a deeper understanding on the underlying social and cultural norms fueling parental reactions to disclosure of sexual orientation.

Interviewing as Data Collection Responsive to Analytical Needs

Ethnography makes it possible to conduct both informal and semi-structured interviews over long periods of time (Marcus, 1998), providing ample opportunities

for theoretical sampling (Coyne, 1997) and triangulation and member checking (Golafshani, 2003; Leech & Onwuegbuzie, 2008). Therefore, analytical needs at the time of the interviews determined the interview script, type of interview, and time span between them. Over the course of the 18 months, I engaged clients and staff in numerous informal interviews. I also conducted single semi-structured interviews with 14 youth between October 2008 and February 2010, and multiple semi-structured interviews with five staff between May 2009 and February 2010.

For youth, the flexible interview guide consisted of open-ended questions on a variety of issues including family relations, gender and sexual orientation experiences, and housing instability. However, the final set of questions ultimately depended on the participant's specific personal history and the analytical needs of the project. For instance, after interviewing 13 youths, I asked a young man his opinion about other youth's reports of discrimination. I said:

I have done some interviews with other youth. I want you to think about something that I've been told: "If you are not good looking, if you have a hard time with interpersonal communicating with people or interacting with people, you are too aggressive, or if you are too dark, you're going to have a hard time getting a place."

Rather than merely descriptive questions, I asked staff higher-order questions on a variety of issues to obtain their professional assessment of chief sources of family conflict and cultural factors shaping reactions to homosexuality. Conducting multiple interviews with staff over a long period of time allowed for triangulating and member checking/obtaining feedback on my analytical interpretations (see the following more detailed explanations). In contrast, because youth were interviewed only once, findings were later discussed with new interviewees.

The interviews were transcribed and added to ATLAS.ti in the original language (English or Spanish). On average, transcripts were 32 pages double-spaced for single interviews with youth and 26 pages for multiple interviews with staff. I created a one-page template for summarizing each youth interview and recording my general observations on the interview. This information was pasted into an ATLAS.ti memo, which was attached to the interview transcript (primary document). Although these summaries were often jotted notes, they were, in fact, one of the first analytical steps of summarizing and categorizing salient data. Table 13.3 shows an excerpt of an interview summary.

Interview summaries *held* the interview as a whole whereas coding *lifted* its parts into analytical categories. By going back to these summaries, I was able to test the typologies I was creating against the complete story of the youth. For instance, I compared generalizations about types of family conflict with concrete descriptions of conflict events to ensure that key elements of their life stories were present in these categories. Importantly, this tension between the particular experiences of the interviewees and conceptual typologies was, and should be, present throughout the data analysis process.

TABLE 13.3 Fragment of an Interview Summary

LYGM2 Summary

Born in NYC, 21yrs old, grew up in NYC until 15–16 when he moved to Florida.

Finished HS and came back to NYC.

Homelessness:

Ran away at 18; before coming back to NYC, for four to five months; slept in park for a couple of weeks; moved in with friends; living in shelters for last two years; has stayed in many different shelters for long periods of time; doesn't like [CBO] because of early curfew; therefore prefers [another CBO]; kicked out by aunt because of lacking a job.

[...] Employment:

While running away, worked for church where he stayed. Worked later at video store.

Unemployed but starting a new job at a porn store.

[...] Friendships and relationships:

Has several friendship networks that he taps into for support; short-term relationships with other guys at shelters; very active sexual life; stories of peer conflict (no physical)

[...] Comments:

LYGM2 seems to enjoy his time off from the expected responsibilities of education and employment in order to explore his sexuality and his connections with gay culture; he defines himself as "sexual;" his background and social networks are emotionally and instrumentally supportive. During the interview, he seemed comfortable but somewhat bored. He got excited when talking about his sexual life in NYC and his mischievousness.

Interviews played an additional role in the analytical process through triangulation and member checking (Golafshani, 2003; Leech & Onwuegbuzie, 2008). Early interviews with youth focused primarily on their experiences. In contrast, later interviews included questions seeking youth's perspectives on identified themes and, equally important, their reactions to my analytical interpretations. The following is an exchange with a youth on the connection between retention in services and compliance with requirements.

DANIEL: Some of the people I interviewed actually said the opposite to what you just said, that one of the reasons why they don't like [organization X] is because they treat you like a child and like in the army. You're telling me something else.

LYGM12: Okay, the reason why people don't like [organization X] is because if you're not working, you have to go to this little program that they have. They say you're supposed to do it. You have the option of doing it or not. [But] people have realized this because many people do not go.

Embedding Literature Reviews Within Data Analysis

Prior to data collection I conducted an integrative literature review, using 26 articles, to increase my understanding of homelessness specifically among gay male youth. Unlike systematic reviews, integrative reviews allow the inclusion

of a variety of methodologies, empirical, and theoretical reports, and a variety of research questions (Whittemore & Knafl, 2005). They provide a broader and deeper analysis of a phenomenon and serve a broad range of purposes (e.g., intervention development, evidence analysis, concept review).

Simultaneously, I conducted a rapid review of the peer-reviewed (i.e., journal articles) and gray literature (e.g., institutional reports, policy reports) on explanations of youth homelessness regardless of sexual orientation. Aimed to obtain reliable but prompt information on a particular issue, rapid reviews focus on a few policy or practice questions, use broader search strategies, target reviews, and restrict the amount of gray literature (Grant & Booth, 2009). Equally important, I utilized rapid reviews to explore additional themes and concepts depending on the data analysis needs. The rapid reviews supported the analytical process by expanding, corroborating, or contradicting findings; furthering the understanding of a concept; or placing my analyses within a larger literature. These literature reviews often trailed the analytical process and, therefore, increased my level of confidence on the provisional conceptual explanations being developed.

The following is a quote from an interview with a staff that created the need for an additional literature review. In this exchange, I described three potential sources of conflict derived from the literature and the analysis: sexual orientation, behavioral disorders, and general family conflict. The program manager's response was:

I think there is a lot of merit to that. If we look at where they're coming from, systemically, the vast majority of them are coming from homes that were unstable long before anyone knew of their orientation, or their gender identity. That right there is a big strike against them. They're coming from an unstable environment, family of a lower socioeconomic status, family members who might have been abusive or drug addicted or alcoholics, etc.

The analysis of this and similar quotes suggested the need for a longer-term perspective on family conflict. A rapid review of the literature led me to Cumulative Risk Theories and Risk Amplification Models (Nesmith, 2006; Whitbeck, Hoyt, & Yoder, 1999). In turn, these models led to a deeper examination of associated codes and the temporal relation of events (e.g., family abuse, truancy, family drug use), which resulted in the creation in Word of a homeless risk table along major categories of family disruption and conflict. Table 13.4 shows the final version of risk distribution along different dimensions.

In combination with the analysis of youth's narratives, the literature on family dynamics suggested that the conflict leading to homelessness was not a discrete moment in family life. Instead, family conflict accumulated over time and amplified the new conflict over sexual orientation, conflating, for instance, histories of truancy with engagement in gay subcultures.

TABLE 13.4 Family Disruptions and Conflicts

<i>Family disruption, conflict</i>	<i>Total youth</i>
Separation from one or both biological parents before first homeless episode	12
Severe home abuse or neglect	5
Ongoing family conflict (pre-coming out)	7
Involvement of foster care or Administration for Children's Services	7
Early home exit	5
Severe and primordial conflict over sexual orientation	3
Family conflict over gay-related lifestyle (explicitly or not)	7

Data Analysis Methods, Strategies, and Tools

Selection of data analysis methods, strategies, and tools was dependent on the stage of the study. Grounded theory was the overall approach for data analysis, and I therefore used the constant comparison method (Whittemore & Knafl, 2005) and its coding types (open, axial, and selective) to develop categories, patterns, themes, and variations. However, although providing a general framework for coding, grounded theory literature lacked good descriptions of the actual coding process—the how. Other authors of qualitative analysis provide better theoretical support and guidance to what open, axial, and focused coding entail, albeit under different names. During axial coding, Domain Analysis (Spradley, 2016) was utilized for developing categories and their relational networks. Finally, during selective coding, strategies from Componential Analysis (Spradley, 2016) helped develop the specific dimensions of particular pathways to homelessness. These strategies included discerning common and unusual patterns, clustering, outlining relations and intervening factors, and cataloguing intra and inter-group characteristics. The utilization of these strategies and associated tools resulted in summaries, code families (an ATLAS.ti term), memos, evidence tables, diagrams, and writing of findings.

Open Coding

Being the only coder and wanting full flexibility, I did not create a formal codebook before or after the open coding. New codes could be created at any time, and older ones were sometimes modified. Over time, the frequency and need for changes to the codes decreased. Overall, open coding consisted of three steps: fragmenting the interview transcripts and fieldnotes (referred to as Primary Documents in ATLAS.ti) into quotations; assigning each quotation one or more labels (codes); and memoing relevant insights about the process. In general, I fragmented the text into quotations based on semantic cohesion instead of syntax or length. In other words, fragments did not follow grammatical rules but instead fragmentation kept words together when they conveyed a particular meaning even if cutting across sentences.

Because quotations can, and often do, convey different meanings, most quotations were assigned more than one code. Some codes were a simple group of nouns such as family composition or employment history. However, as suggested in grounded theory (Charmaz & Belgrave, 2012), most codes utilized a syntactic construction (e.g., gerunds, action verbs, prepositions) that conveyed an analytical function (e.g., descriptive, process, relational, or social interaction). Table 13.5 provides some examples of codes based on their analytical function.

In some instances, I also created an analytical memo to capture the potential uses of a code, its scope, or limitations. Figure 13.1 presents the code “Accepting sexual orientation but not effeminacy” in the code manager, with a memo detailing its meaning and use (lower box), two quotations associated with the code (floating window), and the primary document with the quotation linked to the code (background window).

The creation of memos was particularly important for coding complex narratives or themes in need of further examination such as youth’s descriptions of confusing social interactions with parents regarding sexual orientation. Figure 13.2 provides an example of quotations and the use of some of the previously mentioned codes.

Open coding took slightly different forms and functions throughout the project. After interviewing the first three youths, I open coded the transcripts in a flexible manner without major consideration to a potentially similar code. However, I chose not to use the constant comparison method with these first three interviews so that I had the maximum freedom to assign codes based on a flexible interpretation of each quotation. The result of the first code parsing was a significantly large number of codes (2250). Although the prospect of managing such an incredible number of codes sounds terrifying, it felt liberating to be able to make all kinds of associations without having to worry about fitting a quotation into

TABLE 13.5 Examples of Codes Based on Analytical Function

<i>Analytical function</i>	<i>Code examples</i>
Descriptive codes	“Family composition,” “Employment history”
Process codes	“Migrating to NYC,” “Returning home”
Relational codes	“Accepting sexual orientation but not effeminacy,” “Layering sexual orientation on top of family conflict”
Social interaction codes	“Kicked out for being gay,” “Staying with older man”

SEE FIGURE 13.1 at eResource—Screenshot of a Code With a Memo and Quotations.

SEE FIGURE 13.2 at eResource—Screenshot of a Coded Interview Transcript.

SEE FIGURE 13.3 at eResource—Screenshot of the Code Manager.

a pre-defined code. The process was also helpful later during axial coding, when I started reducing the codes into categories, because I had already a considerable number of nuances (dimensions) for these categories coded.

Next, I reviewed the code manager function (Figure 13.3 presents a screenshot of the code manager) to identify potentially similar codes, a process more in line with the constant comparison method. A printout of the codes and their groundedness (number of quotations associated) allowed me to compare the codes more carefully and then split, merge, or eliminate codes. For example, the initial overarching code “Concealing one’s sexual orientation” was split depending whether it was concealed from the father or the mother. The split helped me examine the more positive reactions of mothers to disclosure as well as the youth’s explanations for concealing information from fathers.

Although I paid more attention to existing codes when coding new interviews, I still used open coding for all of the interview transcripts, regardless of when the interviews had been conducted. The ability to create additional codes ensured that potential new themes were not ignored and nuances of meaning were captured. The presence of a new code signified the presence of data not previously captured in previous data collection and, therefore, deserving of particular scrutiny. After the codes became more stable, the coding process resembled much more a coding process that utilizes a codebook. In fact, grouping dimensions or nuances into a higher conceptual category constituted the beginning of the axial coding process.

Axial Coding

Although codes of higher order were identified early in the analysis, the bulk of axial coding occurred after conducting half of the interviews. I relied primarily on the strategies of Domain Analysis (Spradley, 2016) to identify higher order, overarching categories (i.e., domains or typologies), including constructing a taxonomy of subcategories (i.e., dimensions or components), fully defining these subcategories, and linking related categories. At the practical level, I used ATLAS.ti’s CODES/EDIT FAMILY function for linking codes to create code families (a set of linked codes) and super codes (relational query combining codes). A code family retrieves all the quotations associated with the codes in the family. In contrast, a super code only retrieves those quotations that meet the conditions of a search expression built with operators such as AND, OR, NOT (e.g., all quotations coded with both code “Family conflict” AND “Disclosing sexual orientation”).

Over time, the 2250 codes became a more stable list of 269 code families and 25 super codes, as fewer modifications were necessary and fewer codes added

SEE FIGURE 13.4 at eResource—Screenshot of the Code Family Manager.

(saturation). Because code families and super codes are not specifically attached to a particular quotation but work as a dynamic query of codes, they constituted powerful tools for developing categories and their dimensions, a central step in data analysis. Figure 13.4 provides a screenshot of the code family manager.

Extracting quotations across interviews using the ATLAS.ti managers for code families and super codes can facilitate axial coding, but I also often corroborated the appropriateness of the resulting categories by assessing whether these categories could be confirmed in the context of the transcripts and whether additional nuances had been overlooked. For instance, a youth described family support in these terms: “I still have a family support system that, you know, my father still helps me out. I’m not really on my own yet. He still helps me out, even though I’m not living with him.” Within the larger context, helping out alluded to being able to visit his family and obtaining financial help. The result was linking the codes “Familial instrumental support” and “Familial emotional support” into a code family called “Family support system.”

New interview transcripts, designed to elicit deeper insights, contained information that sometimes resulted in the modification of existing code families or super codes rather than the creation of new ones. To decide whether to create a new code or modify an existing one, I examined the code family’s groundedness (number of quotations) and density (number of linked codes) through the ATLAS.ti code managers to determine the course of action. Over time the code families and super codes became more stable: (a) their distinction from other categories was easier to articulate (boundaries); (b) the components of the definition seemed sufficient and necessary (dimensions); and (c) they indicated how the components related to each other (relations).

In addition to creating code families and super codes, I generated a series of tables and diagrams displaying the relations between categories and analytical memos describing patterns, typologies, or dimensions. These tables and diagrams constituted the beginning of selective coding. Here, the use of grid-like instruments (Timmins & McCabe, 2005) was helpful for mapping relations between categories and dimensions across youths. I created evidence tables in Word and examined them in parallel with primary data analysis. For instance, Table 13.6 shows an excerpt of a table mapping out gay and non-gay related conflict.

Whereas open coding focused on single interviews, the reduction of codes into code families and super codes focused on comparisons between interviews to identify commonalities and differences. This move required a greater theoretical understanding of themes. Therefore, I utilized rapid literature reviews to examine relevant concepts and to compare the subjects’ experiences with those youths in other settings.

TABLE 13.6 Examples of Evidence Table for Histories of Family Conflict and Homelessness

	<i>Non-gay related conflict</i>			<i>Conflict over sexual orientation</i>			
	<i>Severe conflict</i>	<i>Kicked out</i>	<i>Run away</i>	<i>Out to parents</i>	<i>Supportive at time of disclosure</i>	<i>Kicked out</i>	<i>Left home</i>
Agustin	No			Yes	No (parents)		Yes
Hector	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes (parents)		Yes
Frank	Yes		Yes	Yes	No (grandmother)	Yes	Yes
Walter	Yes		Yes	Unspoken	No (mother)		Yes
Rafael	No			Yes	Yes (mother)	Yes	
					No (father)		

In turn, findings from these literature reviews resulted in the creation or modification of analytical memos and tables.

Selective Coding

The final step of coding consisted of the analytical movement from descriptive and semantic to conceptual stories. The integration of concepts around core categories was done through selective coding—finding central, high-level categories that have analytical power to “pull the other categories together to form an explanatory whole” (Corbin & Strauss, 1996, p. 146). Unlike open and axial coding, selective coding started much later in the project after the major super families and super codes became more stable and rich with quotations and memos.

Word tables developed during axial coding were further advanced through the sparing use of componential analysis (Spradley, 2016). This type of analysis searches for attributes (subcomponents of meaning) associated with particular themes (domains) and outline the differences among the attributes. As seen in Table 13.6, I used this strategy to distinguishing among the different components of family conflict over sexual orientation (e.g., disclosure, source of conflict, and outcomes).

Network views (visual representations) of these relationships in ATLAS.ti helped establish relations between higher-order categories. Overall, I utilized network views only for major themes related to the central research questions (pathways to and the course of homelessness) and for a few major themes. Figure 13.5 represents a network view on the negative impact of perceived gay lifestyle on family conflict.

SEE FIGURE 13.5 at eResource—Screenshot of a Network View.

Although code families and super codes constituted theoretical categories, it was the creation of network views rich with codes, quotations, memos, research findings, and their inter-relations that provided the structure and content of theoretical findings. Furthermore, these visual representations allowed the texts to be readily accessible throughout the process. Clicking on an element in the network view displayed the actual quotations, primary documents, or memos. Having direct and rapid access to the actual quotation, for instance, served as a counterpoint to the theoretical developments, sometimes harmonically providing conceptual strength but sometimes dissonantly unsettling the theoretical arguments.

Memoing

The analytical material practices described previously (coding, categorizing, building explanatory models) generated a great level of textual data in the form of memos. In some cases, these memos included suggestions for reviewing a transcript, modifying code structures, or collecting new data. The systematic and iterative process described in this chapter also applies to memoing. Multiple rereadings and relistening of interviews throughout the project helped clarify early memos and resulted in new ones with deeper analytical insights.

ATLAS.ti provided great flexibility in the creation, manipulation, and categorizing of memos. Although all analytical objects in ATLAS.ti can include comments/notes, memos became more central as my analysis progressed from open coding to selective coding. Memos can be linked to specific quotations, codes, and other memos as well as embedded in network views. For instance, I utilized the “type” field to distinguish between memos that were summaries, commentaries, methodological issues, or theoretical insights to facilitate the retrieval and cataloguing. I also assigned memos a meaningful title related to the analysis in order to facilitate retrieval. Figure 13.6 shows a screenshot of a memo in the code manager with a linked quotation in an interview transcript.

Overall, I could distinguish three different stages for memoing, albeit not strictly sequential. At the beginning, memos were more descriptive, written directly in ATLAS.ti, and attached to quotations. Over time, they became more analytical. I wrote them in Word because of better editing capabilities but I uploaded them into ATLAS.ti, sometimes as a free memo but often connected to code families or network views. Finally, memos became longer, resembling theoretical insights explicating the experiences of the participants. Because these memos were more reliant on theoretical concepts than on particular quotations, code families, or network views, I wrote them in Word but did not upload them to ATLAS.ti. These memos were in fact proto-essays on particular research questions.

Reflections

My previous experiences with qualitative analysis (Padilla et al., 2008) had included more defined and structured parameters, including formalized research questions, interviewing scripts, and codebooks. Given the flexible approach in this project, I found myself hesitating about the relevance of the interview questions to the overall progress of the project. I questioned whether to devote resources to member checking and triangulation, conduct additional tinkering with coding, or explore additional leads. Because I used a variety of methods and strategies, I also worried about selecting the appropriate analytical strategies to increase the plausibility of the arguments.

Deciding when to move from one stage of data analysis to the next constituted an additional challenge. Given that data collection, data analysis, and literature reviews were conducted simultaneously, the concurrent and iterative process felt overwhelmingly repetitive, chaotic, and onerous. I often wanted to push forward but I was afraid that by moving too fast through the analytical stages, I might overlook key outliers or underdeveloped themes. The ongoing and systematic documentation of the data analysis process, particularly through memoing, provided some solace to these concerns. In addition, I felt that the limitations of a particular strategy or tool were addressed through the use of a different one, increasing my confidence in the thoroughness of the analysis. Although the hesitation and uncertainty did not completely vanish, I felt more confident by ensuring tasks were implemented systematically and developing explicit criteria for advancing to the next stage.

KEY WORKS GUIDING MY DATA ANALYSIS

Charmaz, K., & Belgrave, L. (2012). Qualitative interviewing and grounded theory analysis. In J. F. Gubrium, J. A. Holstein, A. B. Marvasti, & K. D. McKinney (Eds.), *The Sage handbook of interview research: The complexity of the craft* (2nd ed., pp. 347–366). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.

This chapter illustrates how a grounded theory approach shapes the interviewing process as well as the data analysis. In doing so, the authors emphasize the flexibility of the data collection and analysis strategies and the inductive and iterative nature of grounded theory. In particular, they provided me with guidance for developing interview scripts that would elicit participants' own understanding of their experiences and for implementing theoretical sampling in order to address the data collection needs of the data analysis. Overall, this chapter made more concrete to me the praxis involved in adopting a grounded theory approach.

Leech, N. L., & Onwuegbuzie, A. J. (2008). Qualitative data analysis: A compendium of techniques and a framework for selection for school psychology research and beyond. *School Psychology Quarterly*, 23, 587–604.

This article provides an overview of the 18 most common methods used for qualitative data analysis, from word count to domain analysis to semiotics, including the philosophical or theoretical underpinnings of each method and strategy. In addition to providing me with core practical tasks, this article validated the utilization of multiple and diverse strategies during qualitative analysis.

Konopásek, Z. (2007). Making thinking visible with Atlas.ti: Computer assisted qualitative analysis as textual practices. *Historical Social Research/Historische Sozialforschung*, Supplement, 276–298.

This paper makes a critique of data analysis understood as “mental processes and conceptual work” (abstract). The author proposes understanding it instead as a material praxis, a set of material practices that are visible and traceable. Through a concrete discussion of grounded theory methodology and the utilization of ATLAS.ti, the author provided me with a deeper understanding of the material practices and products constituting the process of data analysis.

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Figure 13.1

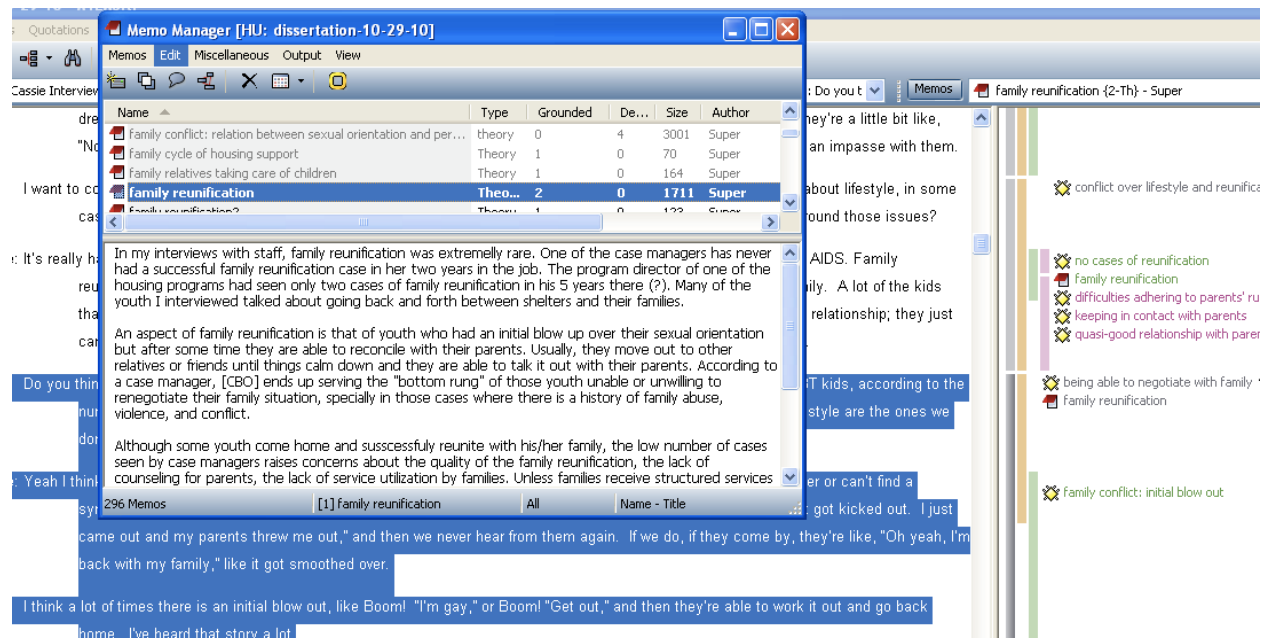


Figure 13.2

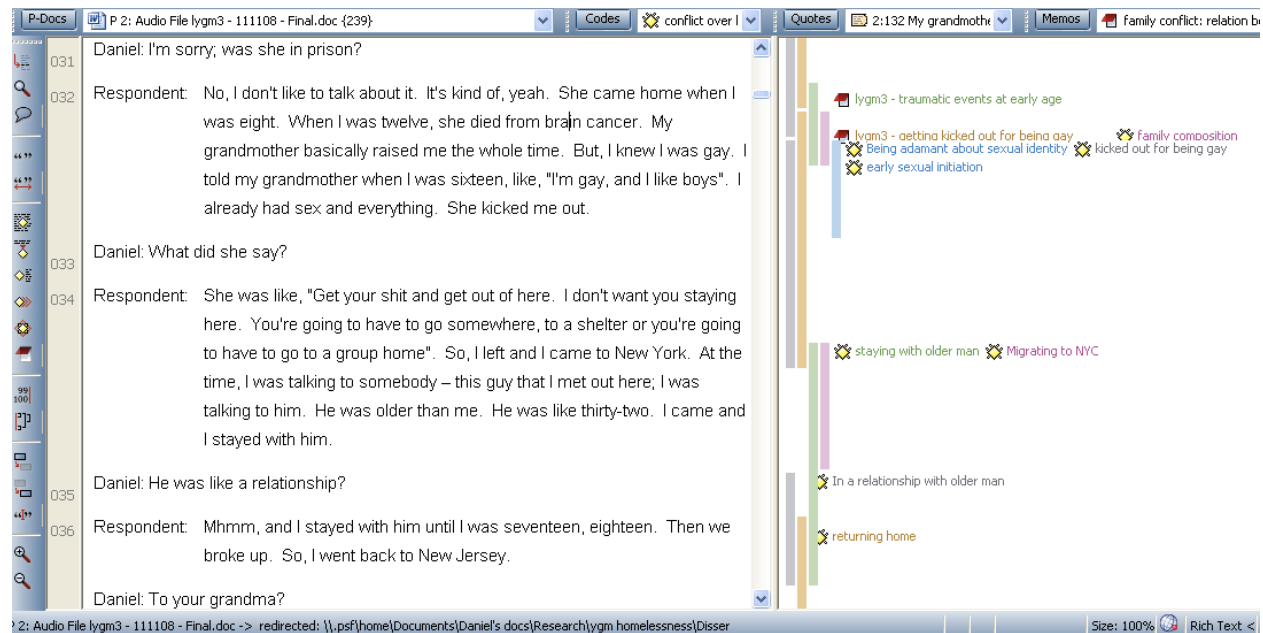


Figure 13.3

Code Manager [HU: dissertation-10-29-10]

Codes Edit Miscellaneous Output View

Icons: [Icons for file operations and editing]

Name	Grounded	Density	Author	
complaining about being asked to do things at housing	1	0	Super	03/03/2010
complains about rules	1	0	Super	02/07/2010
complains about staff attitude	1	0	Super	02/07/2010
complete passing and employment	1	0	Super	04/17/2010
compromising needs and priorities	1	0	Super	04/17/2010
concealing at school~	4	0	Super	10/27/2009
concealing from his mother	1	0	Super	06/16/2010
concealing gay identity to stay at a church	1	0	Super	10/26/2009
concealing homelessness from dates	2	0	Super	02/06/2010
concealing homelessness from his father	2	0	Super	06/16/2010
concealing info from friends	1	0	Super	10/26/2009
concealing information	1	0	Super	02/06/2010
concealing information on sexuality	1	0	Super	06/17/2010
concealing relationship with older guy	1	0	Super	10/30/2009
concern of imposing staff's views over client's	1	0	Super	04/16/2010

*** Merged with: coming out at school (2010-06-13T00:15:36) ***

>>-Comment/body for "coming out at school":
 issues of concealing and coming out at school
 <<-End of comment/body for "coming out at school"

2873 Codes [1] concealing at school All Name - Title

Figure 13.4

Code Family Manager [HU: dissertation-10-29-10]

Families Edit Miscellaneous View

Icons: [New] [Open] [Save] [Print] [Filter] [Delete] [Copy] [Paste] [Find]

Name	Size	Quotes	Author	Created
*Interpersonal: Peers and friends~	99	*	Super	09/07/2010 10:4...
*Personal determinants	944	*	Super	03/24/2011 02:1...
*Personal determinants: Education: College -done + Person..	50	*	Super	07/07/2011 02:3...
*Sex work	28	*	Super	11/12/2010 05:2...
adolescence to review	33	*	Super	05/12/2011 03:3...
Adolescent experimentation - done	11	13	Super	11/08/2010 08:5...
Adolescent normative and arrested development - done~	20	21	Super	09/17/2010 12:1...
Adolescent: being an adolescent - done	5	5	Super	11/08/2010 08:5...
Behavioral: behavioral problems -done	3	5	Super	11/13/2010 04:0...
Behavioral: Condom use - done	18	21	Super	09/06/2010 04:5...
Behavioral: deviant behavior - done	15	14	Super	09/07/2010 11:3...
Behavioral: Having sex - done	44	53	Super	09/06/2010 04:1...
Behavioral: Self-harming behavior - done	9	12	Super	09/16/2010 11:5...

Navigation: [Previous] [Next]

ageing out of clubbing {1-0}

arrested development or a missed childhood {1-0}

attachment issues {1-0}

becoming more mature {1-0}

chronic ignoring of gender issues {1-0}

developmental delays {3-0}

differences responses to being validated {1-0}

<

>

a lot of things happening in foster care {1-0}

a way to dick around {1-0}

abuse as a stressor of family life {1-0}

Abuse at foster care {1-0}

acceptance: accepted by friends for what he is {2-0}

acceptance: Accepting son's homosexuality {3-0}

accepting his HIV status {1-0}

This code family captures the ways in which sexual orientation shapes adolescent development among young gay latino men.

269 Families | Adolescent normative and arrest

Figure 13.5

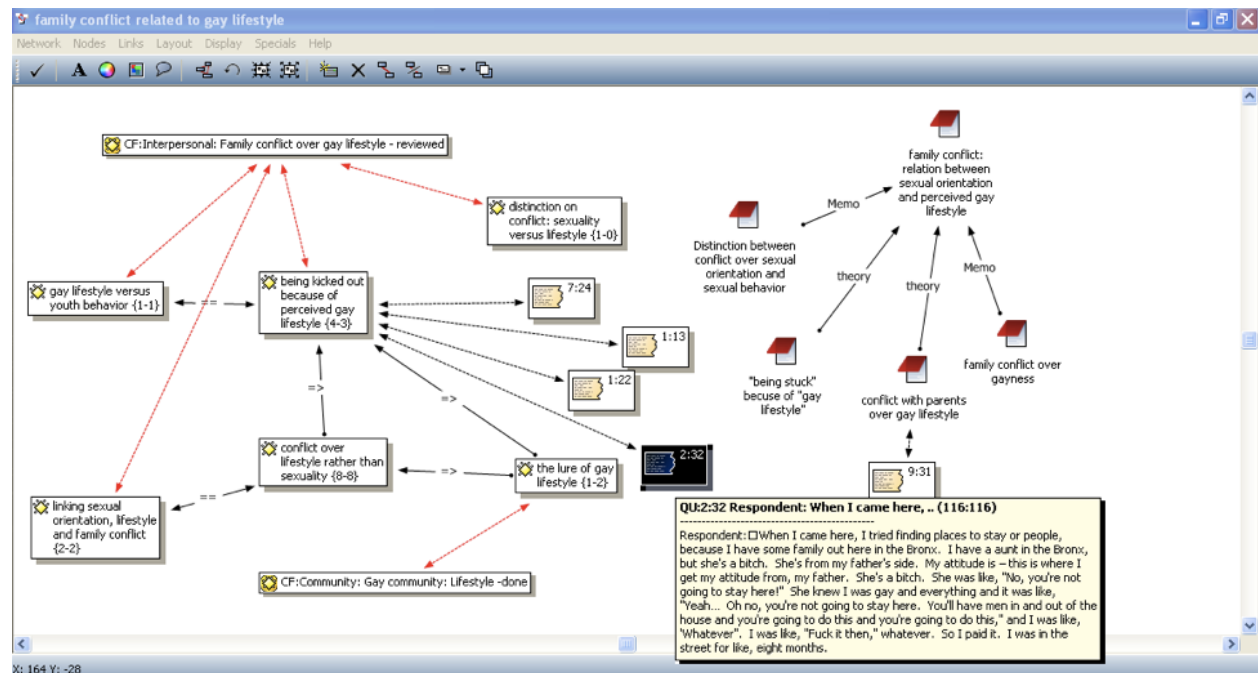


Figure 13.6

